



FROST DATES & SEASON

Last frost: February 10 – March 5
First frost: November 20 – December 15
Season: 260–300 days

THIS MONTH — MAY 2026

1. Spring garden in full production — harvest cucumbers & squash frequently to maximize yield before summer heat peaks.
2. Cool-season window has closed: remove spent lettuce, spinach, peas & broccoli now. Do not let them bolt and deplete soil.
3. Begin planning summer survival: okra, southern peas & sweet potatoes are the summer workhorses. Get okra in the ground now.

QUICK-START CROPS

Okra — Cow Horn (H) or Clemson Spineless (H)
Sow April, harvest June–November. High success, minimal care, productive in Zone 9 heat.

Heat Wave II or Solar Fire tomato (OP)
Bred for heat-set — these set fruit at high temperatures when standard varieties drop their blossoms.

California Blackeye cowpea (OP)
Southern pea for Zone 9 summer. Direct sow April–June, nitrogen-fixing and edible beans.

STORAGE & PRESERVATION

- Two preservation windows: spring (Feb–April, before heat) and fall (Oct–Dec, after heat). Plan canning sessions around these.
- Process spring tomatoes April–May before the crop is finished. Fall tomatoes ripen October–November for a second session.
- Freeze crushed tomatoes if April heat makes kitchen canning impractical — process them in October when temperatures are bearable.

ZONE
9

Gulf Coast, Southern Texas,
Central Florida, SoCal Inland
Houston TX · Jacksonville FL · Sacramento CA

HEIRLOOM VARIETY SPOTLIGHT

Tropic tomato (OP)
Bred at University of Florida for tropical heat. 72 days, disease-resistant, heat-set. The Zone 9 workhorse.

Cow Horn okra (H)
Longer pods (8–12 in), classic Southern heirloom, prolific in Zone 9 heat. Harvest at 4–6 in for best texture.

Zipper Cream cowpea (OP)
Named for the easy-to-shell pod. Rich, creamy texture. Most popular Southern pea for Zone 9 home gardeners.